

bugbear and every action now has an equal and apposite reaction.

The mediums are different. Some stars use favoured freelancers who shop strategically timed interviews to celebrity-starved newspapers and magazines. Sometimes the most favoured newspapers carry extensive reaction interviews. Film magazines have always thrived on these stories, often dismissed as rumours by the subjects and always authenticated by 'reliable sources'. But now stars have decided to show some aggression. It could be Shah Rukh and Saif Ali Khan hosting a film awards show and displaying their somewhat twisted sense of humour—mocking everyone, including themselves. So Kumar is dubbed a wedding dancer, Yash Chopra's accent is said to be incomprehensible and Vidhu Vinod Chopra has effected the greatest comeback, because *Eklavya* came back from the Oscars without an award.

The media couldn't have had it better. This newfound outspokenness provides a dustup a day. Once there was just a suicide bomber named Mahesh Bhatt who could be trusted to stop the clocks for a second. Now everyone is a seasoned sniper. Journalism has become one long table tennis match, with the readers waiting to see where the next shot is hit. One day it is Bachchan taking potshots at Shah Rukh's Star Plus game show *Kya Aap Paanchvi Paas Se Tez Hain?* (or rather, quoting a rival channel executive calling it 'Paanchvi Fail'). Another day, it is Shah Rukh reacting to being called a dog. And yet another day, it is Salman apparently instructing Katrina Kaif not to work with Kumar. Blogs, specifically, have given a shelf life to what were once ephemeral remarks—if you caught them on the evening news, good, otherwise, you just went on to the next issue of the day. Which may be why actors are using them as promotional tools, whether for releasing stills of

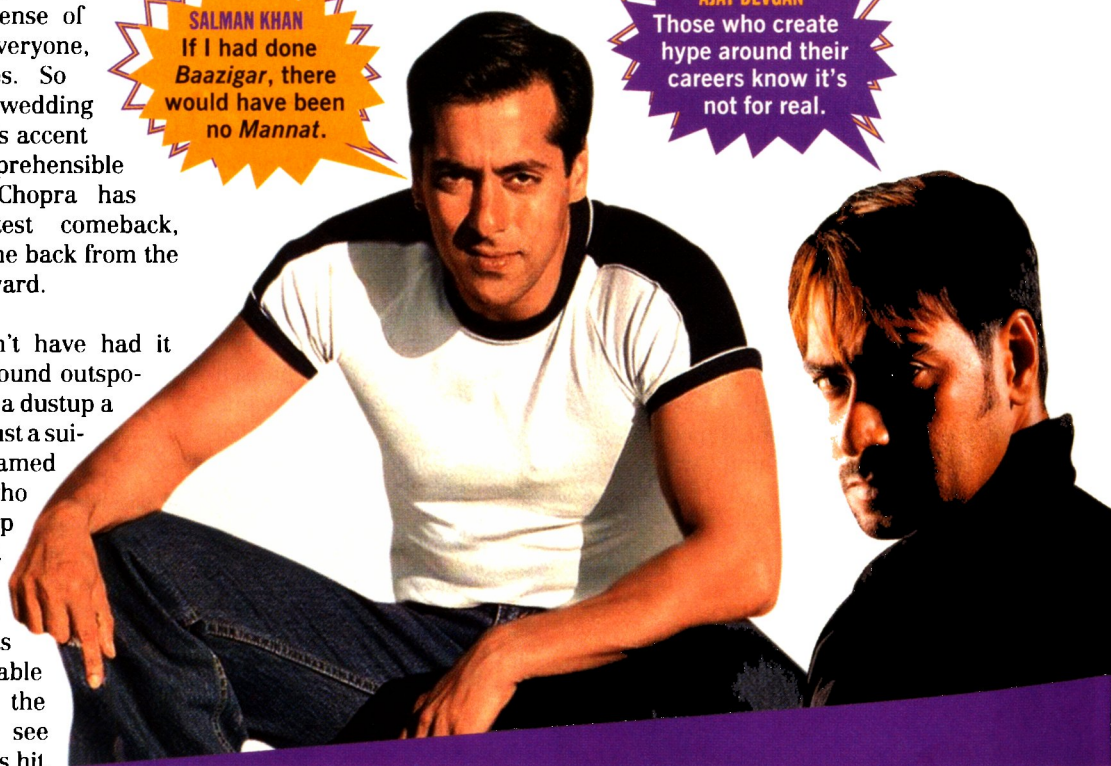
Sarkar Raj or pictures of Aamir's soon-to-be-launched nephew Imran.

So why are Bollywoodians letting it all hang out? It's partly a result of the media, which now really doesn't care about the star. It only chases the story. Those who provide access, even if it is to utter inanities, get away with a lot. Those who don't—as the Bachchans were perceived not to have done, when they kept the media and several stars out of the Abhishek-Aishwarya wedding—have to surrender their unimpeachable status. Which is why

happen in Hollywood, which also has its little exclusive clubs (George Clooney and friends, Tom Cruise and the scientologists being the prime posses)? It can't, because everything the stars say usually goes through several filters of personal publicists and studio bosses. Any time the star doesn't follow the plot, he's dropped—witness what happened to Cruise after his couch-jumping on Oprah Winfrey's show. Bollywood studios have none of that clout—the stars are their own gatekeepers.

SALMAN KHAN
If I had done
Baazigar, there
would have been
no *Mannat*.

AJAY DEVGAN
Those who create
hype around their
careers know it's
not for real.



so many famously reticent people have now become media regulars, whether it is Kajol, who used the media selectively to promote *U, Me, Aur Hum*, or Salman, who now talks up every big release—even if it sometimes makes him look silly, as it did during *Saawariya*, in which he was onscreen for fleeting minutes.

It's also a result of the Bollywood business becoming more transparent, and a lot more competitive. With studios now keen to declare star salaries and box office revenues, it's easy to see who stands where professionally. Does such sniping

How long will this detoxification continue? After all, Shah Rukh, the first one to challenge the accepted norms in Bollywood at the Zee Cine Awards in 2004, had to make peace with the Bachchans at a time when his career was not going particularly well. Much later, Aamir apologised to Bachchan for his statement on *Black*, while Bachchan said sorry to Shah Rukh for his remark on *Paanchvi Paas*, and even more recently, Aamir offered his sincere apologies to Shah Rukh and his fans. Bollywood's designer dreaminess can't stand too much dog-eat-dog. ■